



Big Basin Day-Trip Planner

California's first state park, nine miles up Highway 236 from downtown Boulder Creek. It reopened after the 2020 CZU fire, but not as the park in the old postcards. Knowing what "open" means right now is the difference between a good day and a locked gate.

ONE RULE BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

Check the official Big Basin Redwoods State Park page the morning you go. Access has changed in phases since the fire, trails open and close with storm damage and clearing work, and nothing on this sheet guarantees a given trail, road, or lot will be open the day you arrive.

THE NUMBERS

Hours	8 a.m. to sunset, day use only. There is no overnight access in the main park.
Parking	\$6 per regular vehicle plus a \$2 reservation fee, or \$10 per vehicle without a reservation. Spaces are limited, so a reservation is strongly recommended rather than strictly required.
Free entry	No fee and no reservation if you arrive on foot, by bike, or by bus.
Getting there	About 9 miles up Highway 236 from downtown Boulder Creek. Narrow and curvy: plan on half an hour, not a quick hop.
Oversized	Oversized vehicles and trailers cannot be accommodated for day-use parking. Leave the RV behind.

BEFORE YOU LEAVE TOWN

- ☐ **Reserve parking** through the Friends of Santa Cruz State Parks system at thatsmypark.org. The passenger-vehicle form is separate from disabled parking and bus or trailer parking.
- ☐ **Fill your water bottles.** State Parks says there is no potable water in the park, only pre-filled reusable bottles for sale.
- ☐ **Fuel up and buy food in Boulder Creek.** There are no services along Highway 236 and only limited, temporary facilities inside the park.
- ☐ **Check the park page and the forecast.** Heat, wind after storms, and road damage all affect this park, and if the park says don't come, don't come.
- ☐ **Pull up the current trail map** before you commit to a route.

WHAT TO EXPECT ON THE GROUND

The reliable first walk is the **Redwood Loop Trail**, an easy 0.6-mile loop through old-growth redwoods near the historic park core, where fire scars and bright new growth sit on the same thousand-year-old trunks. Crews have reopened roughly four more miles in a recent round of work, restoring access to **Sempervirens Falls** and segments of the **Skyline to the Sea Trail**. Closures still come and go: State Parks currently lists the Hollow Tree Trail as temporarily closed after winter storm damage. Facilities are limited and shade is thinner than it used to be, so treat any trail list, including this one, as a snapshot.

CAMPING: CLOSED IN THE MAIN PARK

Every campground in the main park is closed, no camping reservations are available there, and State Parks lists every backcountry trail camp as closed from fire damage. The one exception is on the coastal side: the **Rancho del Oso** Horse Camp has a handful of temporary walk-in campsites by reservation plus one shared bike-in site. Rancho del Oso is also open for day use, with no fee or reservation at its Nature and History Center.

GETTING THERE WITHOUT DRIVING

On summer weekends between Memorial Day weekend and Labor Day weekend, State Parks has run a **free shuttle** from a temporary parking area at Saddle Mountain along Highway 236 to the main day-use area, and **Santa Cruz METRO Route 35B** has offered weekend bus service to the park. Both are seasonal, so confirm they are running before you plan around them. Arriving this way also means no parking fee and no reservation.

WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY LOOKING AT

Big Basin became California's first state park in 1902, and Boulder Creek has been its gateway town ever since. In August 2020 the CZU Lightning Complex fire reached the park two days after igniting and burned roughly 18,000 acres inside it, more than 97 percent, destroying nearly every structure including the historic headquarters. Most of the old-growth redwoods survived. What you will find is rarer than the old postcard: an old-growth forest rebuilding itself in the open sun, with green regrowth climbing blackened trunks and new trail mileage opening in phases. Stay on open trails and respect every closure sign; the recovery work is what reopens the rest.

Hours, fees, camping status, trail closures, water availability, and shuttle details from California State Parks and Friends of Santa Cruz State Parks; fire figures from Friends of Santa Cruz State Parks; reopening history from State Parks and Sempervirens Fund. Checked July 2026. Conditions in this park change month to month: the official park page is always the source of truth, and this sheet is not.